Free GPU Cloud Credits

Programs, eligibility, and how long they actually last for one department of ~100 users

Noviq internal · Data current July 2026 · Companion to *LLM Provider & Model Analysis (July 2026)*

The single most important finding, before any table.

The question "how long will free credits last for 100 users?" contains a hidden assumption that does not hold: **GPU credits are not consumed by users or by tokens — they are consumed by wall-clock time the instance exists.** A rented GPU bills identically whether it serves 100 queries or zero.

Measured against Noviq's actual load (§3), 100 users keep a single mid-range GPU busy roughly **5% of the day**. If that instance runs 24/7 you are paying for about **20 hours of idle for every hour of work**. Consequently the operating pattern changes your runway by **3–10×** — far more than the choice of provider, GPU, or credit programme does. §5 quantifies this; §6 is the resulting recommendation.

1. Credit programmes — what is actually obtainable

Programme	Amount	Expiry	Eligibility	Assessment for Noviq
Self-serve — no application, available today				
Google Cloud free trial	$300	90 days	New account, card required	TAKE NOW Immediate, no gatekeeping. Enough for a full pilot (§5).
Azure free account	$200	30 days	New account	MARGINAL Short window; GPU quota often needs a separate request that eats the month.
Oracle Cloud free tier	$300	30 days	New account	MARGINAL 30-day expiry is the binding constraint, not the money.
AWS free tier	~$200	varies	New account	MARGINAL GPU instances are largely outside the free tier.
Application-based — weeks of lead time, far larger amounts				
NVIDIA Inception	$10k–25k typical up to $100k	1–2 yr	**No fee, no equity, no funding minimum, no cohort deadline**	HIGHEST PRIORITY The only large programme with no funding or investor prerequisite. Bootstrapped teams typically land $10k–25k. Also unlocks AWS Activate and Nebius tiers below.
NVIDIA DGX Cloud (via Inception)	up to $100k	1–2 yr	Inception member, by request	STRETCH Dedicated H100 capacity — far more GPU than this workload needs.
Nebius AI Lift (via Inception)	up to $150k + $10k inference	1–2 yr	Inception member	STRETCH Largest single number found. Worth asking once Inception is in place.
AWS Activate	$1k entry up to $100k	1–2 yr	$1k tier open to any startup; higher tiers need an accelerator/VC referral	TAKE THE $1k The entry tier needs no investor. Higher tiers realistically require the NIC/SEIC association.
Microsoft Founders Hub	$1k entry up to $150k	staged	Live product with verified traction — *not* institutional funding	GOOD FIT Scales on demonstrated usage rather than investors. Noviq has a live deployment, which is the qualifying evidence.
Google for Startups	up to $350k	1–2 yr	Accelerator or VC association	GATED Largest headline, but needs the association Noviq does not yet have.
Oracle for Startups	$500–100k	varies	Accelerator/VC association	GATED

> **Recommended sequence.** (1) Apply to **NVIDIA Inception** today — no fee, no equity, no funding minimum, and it is the gateway to the AWS and Nebius tiers. (2) Take the **$1k AWS Activate** and **Microsoft Founders Hub** entry tiers, neither of which requires an investor. (3) Use the **$300 Google Cloud** trial immediately for the pilot, since it needs no application at all. (4) Revisit Google for Startups and Oracle for Startups *after* the NIC/SEIC association is formalised — that association is what unlocks the gated tiers.

2. GPU rental rates — what the credits are spent against

Qwen3-8B at `max_model_len=8192` needs roughly 16 GB for weights in FP16 plus KV cache and overhead. It already runs in production on a 12 GB A40 slice, so any 24 GB card is comfortable and a 48 GB card is generous.

Option	GPU	$/hour	$/month 24×7	$/month 10×22	Note
Specialist clouds (RunPod / Lambda / Vast)	L40S 48 GB	$0.39–1.00	$285–730	$86–220	40–85% cheaper than hyperscalers. No enterprise contract.
GCP g2-standard-4	L4 24 GB	$0.70	$511	$154	**Best fit.** Cheapest hyperscaler card that comfortably holds the model.
AWS g5.xlarge	A10G 24 GB	$1.006	$734	$221	Closest match to the current A40 slice.
AWS g6e.xlarge	L40S 48 GB	~$1.88	$1,372	$414	Headroom for a larger model later.
GCP A100 40 GB	A100	$3.67	$2,679	$807	OVERKILL ~5× the needed capacity at this load.
Spot / preemptible	any	−50–70%	—	—	Interruptible. Viable for indexing, not for interactive chat.

3. Sizing the actual load — 1 department, ~100 users

Stated assumptions, so the arithmetic can be corrected if any is wrong:

Assumption	Value	Basis
Licensed users in the department	100	Given.
Daily active share	30%	Typical internal-tool engagement; 30 users/day.
Queries per active user per day	10	Research-style usage.
Queries per day	**300**	Derived.
Prompt tokens per query	~8,000	Measured Noviq RAG prompt (retrieved passages + grounding prefix).
Generated tokens per answer	~500	Current answer lengths.
GPU seconds per query	~15 s	~3 s prefill + ~12 s decode on a 24 GB card.
GPU-hours of real compute per day	**~1.25 h**	300 × 15 s.
Peak simultaneous requests	3–5	300 queries clustered into office hours.

> **What this means.** One department of 100 users needs about **1.25 GPU-hours of compute per day** — roughly **5% utilisation** of a single 24 GB card running around the clock. A single L4 or A10G is not merely sufficient; it is already over-provisioned. The constraint is *peak concurrency* (3–5 simultaneous requests, which vLLM batches comfortably), never total throughput.
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> The practical implication: **scaling from 100 to 300 users would not require a second GPU.** The cost model is dominated by uptime, not headcount — so do not price additional departments as additional GPUs until concurrency, not volume, actually forces it.

4. Runway — how long each credit pot lasts

Runway on a **GCP L4 at $0.70/hr**, the recommended target. Three operating patterns:

- **24/7** — instance always up (730 h/month, $511/month).
- **Business hours** — up 10 h/day × 22 days (220 h/month, $154/month). Requires a start/stop schedule.
- **Autoscale-to-zero** — instance runs only when serving (~40 h/month, ~$28/month). Requires tolerating cold starts.

Credit pot	GPU-hours	24/7	Business hours	Scale-to-zero	Capped by
Azure $200	286	12 days	1.3 months	7 months	30-day expiry
Oracle $300	428	18 days	1.9 months	10 months	30-day expiry
Google Cloud $300	428	18 days	1.9 months	10 months	90-day expiry
AWS Activate $1,000	1,428	2.0 months	6.5 months	~3 years	credit
Founders Hub $1,000	1,428	2.0 months	6.5 months	~3 years	credit
Inception $10,000	14,285	1.6 years	5.4 years	credit expiry	1–2 yr expiry
Inception $25,000	35,714	4.1 years	expiry	expiry	1–2 yr expiry
AWS Activate $100,000	142,857	16 years	expiry	expiry	1–2 yr expiry

> **Read the last column.** From $10,000 upward the binding constraint stops being money and becomes the **credit expiry date**. At Inception scale you physically cannot spend the credits on one department's inference before they expire — which reframes the question from "can we afford it" to "what else should we run on them." Fine-tuning experiments, batch re-indexing and evaluation runs are the natural answer, and unlike inference they can use interruptible spot capacity.

4.1 Direct answer to the question asked

Scenario	Runway, 1 dept / 100 users	Comment
What you can start with **today**, no application ($300 GCP)	**~2 months** business-hours (18 days if left 24/7)	Enough to run a complete departmental pilot.
Realistic position in ~1 month (Inception $10–25k + AWS/Azure $1k each)	**1.5–4 years** at 24/7 longer if scheduled	Comfortably covers the first paying deployment with room for training work.
Cost after credits run out	**$154–511/month**	Per department, one L4. Against a per-institution licence this is a small line item.

5. Why the operating pattern dominates

Same $300, same GPU, same 100 users — runway varies **17×** purely by uptime policy:

Pattern	Hours/month	$/month	$300 lasts	Cost of the pattern
Always on (default)	730	$511	18 days	None — but ~95% is idle spend.
Scheduled start/stop	220	$154	1.9 months	No service outside office hours. Usually acceptable for a government department.
Autoscale to zero	~40	~$28	10 months	30–90 s cold start on the first query after idle. Needs a warm-up ping or a UI affordance.

A scheduled stop/start is a cron job and a systemd unit — a few hours of work that multiplies every credit pot in §4 by roughly 3.3×. It is the highest-return item in this document.

6. Recommendations

1. **Apply to NVIDIA Inception this week.** No fee, no equity, no funding minimum, no deadline — and it gates the AWS and Nebius tiers. It is the highest-value action available and costs nothing but the application.
2. **Take the $300 Google Cloud trial now** for the pilot. It needs no application, and an L4 at $0.70/hr is the best price/fit match for Qwen3-8B.
3. **Implement scheduled start/stop before spending any credits.** It multiplies every pot by ~3.3× and is a few hours of work. Do this first, not after the credits start draining.
4. **Do not provision an A100 or H100.** At 5% utilisation of an L4, larger cards buy nothing but burn rate. Revisit only if the model grows beyond ~13B or concurrency exceeds ~20.
5. **Size the second department by concurrency, not headcount.** One L4 should absorb several departments. Do not price additional GPUs into the commercial model until measured peak concurrency demands it.
6. **Confirm the data-boundary position before committing to a foreign hyperscaler.** A government department's corpus moving to AWS/GCP is a policy question, not a cost question. The NTC ↔ Data Vault government GPUaaS arrangement already noted in our business planning would resolve both the boundary story and the GPU cost — get pricing from them before locking in a cloud, because that route may make this entire analysis moot.

> **Caveats.** Credit amounts are what programmes advertise; actual awards vary with reviewer discretion and are frequently lower than the headline. Most credits exclude some services and carry 1–2 year expiries. GPU quota is a separate approval from credits on AWS, GCP and Azure, and often takes days — apply for quota early. All hourly rates are on-demand US-region list prices from July 2026 and vary by region.

7. Sources

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